WILLIAMS, MAYE A BUDDING RIVALRY?

Two stars of the 2024 quarterback draft class meet tonight as Bears host defending AFC champion Patriots. **Sports**

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WAR IN UKRAINE

Putin agrees to new talks

Zelenskyy sought summit with US to break impasse

ASSOCIATED PRESS

Russian President Vladimir Putin agreed Wednesday to resume three-way negotiations next month with Washington and Kyiv aimed at ending the war in Ukraine, a Kremlin official said, potentially setting up the first such talks since February.

The Russian leader agreed "in principle" to resume the talks after Nov. 10, Putin foreign affairs adviser Yuri Ushakov said following a meeting in St. Petersburg between Putin and U.S. envoy Steve Witkoff. The talks will focus on "building a security system for Russia and Ukraine after the conflict ends," Ushakov said.

Witkoff's talks with Putin about Moscow's full-scale invasion of Ukraine took place as President Donald Trump pushed Kyiv to make a deal that stops the fighting.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said he supported the push from Washington to restart talks swiftly. "The agenda is clear: to end the war, bring peace closer, and, as I understand it, prepare everything for a meeting at the leaders' level," Zelenskyy said in an audio message issued late Wednesday.

Zelenskyy has insisted that only a summit of leaders can break the impasse. The two armies remain locked on the battlefield, and the countries pummel each other with daily long-range strikes.

Representatives of the three countries held three rounds of negotiations early

See **UKRAINE** on Page A9

MICHIGAN MAN FREED: Russia on Wednesday freed an American who had been jailed for more than four years on charges of fighting as a mercenary in Ukraine. **Nation & World, Page B4**

CHICAGO CITY BUDGET

JOHNSON PITCHES 'FAIR SHARE' PLAN

Eyes on future: Mayor vows head tax would be investment in city's children

'Out of whack': $17.6 billion target faces long road to approval in split council



Ald. Bill Conway, 34th, playfully does bicep curls with copies of the budget on Wednesday at Chicago City Hall. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Proposal sets aside $286M for CPS, but district's financial outlook remains shaky

By Kate Armanini and Jake Sheridan
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Mayor Brandon Johnson's proposed city budget includes $286 million for Chicago Public Schools — in line with what the school board budgeted in late July, but only half of what the cash-strapped district received last year.

The $286 million comes from a surplus of funds from special taxing districts, known as tax increment financing, or TIF. When officials declare a surplus, they return the money proportionally to the taxing bodies, with about half going to CPS and a quarter to the city. This year, Johnson's budget proposal includes a total TIF surplus of $522 million, officials said.

CPS and city officials have increasingly relied on TIF to plug perennial budget gaps. The school district initially

See **CPS** on Page A2

76%

The mayor hopes to close 76% of Chicago's projected $882.4 million budget deficit. That includes the reworked head tax, which could net $102 million if passed, a boost to lease transaction taxes up to 20% worth another $234 million, and a smattering of other tweaks to levies.

By Alice Yin, Jake Sheridan and A.D. Quig
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Mayor Brandon Johnson told aldermen Wednesday it's imperative to invest in Chicago's future generation in the next budget, a rousing and unsurprising election year speech delivered to a City Council that has so far refused to rally to his tax-the-rich ideas.

"James Baldwin said that the children are always ours, every single one of them. He was right," Johnson said. "He also said that he was beginning to suspect that whoever is incapable of recognizing that may be incapable of morality."

Johnson's $17.6 billion spending proposal for 2027 is up $760 million from this year and revitalizes his corporate head tax proposal with a twist. Now named the "equitable employee tax,"

See **BUDGET** on Page A4

ELECTION 2026 4TH CONGRESSIONAL DISTRICT

Unrepentant García defends path to vacant seat



Patty García, Democratic nominee for the 4th Congressional District, marches in a Mexican Independence Day parade in Little Village on Sept. 13. **EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Handpicked by predecessor, progressive says she's best qualified to take on Trump

By Jake Sheridan
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Patty García's path to Congress was paved long before Election Day. The challenge now for the first-time candidate: Shaping how the voters she wants to represent see her.

Her pitch was clear as she spoke to campaign volunteers in Chicago's Back of the Yards neighborhood in September.

She was raised by an immigrant father, a union worker once laid off by a company greedy for "cheap labor," she told the crowd. She objects to taxpayer dollars spent on Israeli weapons. She wants to "abolish ICE," the U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement agency.

"Abolishing ICE means holding those agents accountable that have kidnapped our neighbors, that have killed our fathers in the neighborhood, our mothers," she said, referring to Silverio Villegas González, who was fatally shot by a federal agent in Franklin Park in September 2025. "Abolishing ICE means not one more penny to this rogue agency with a blank check, working unchecked."

But just as telling as García's working-class

See **CONGRESS** on Page A2

SENATE DEBATE: Candidates for the state's open U.S. Senate seat clashed Tuesday over the war in Iran, immigration and affordability, with Republican Don Tracy largely backing President Donald Trump's policies and Democrat Juliana Stratton pledging to check presidential power. **Chicagoland, Page A3**

■ Rising costs of childcare weigh on some voters in swing states. **Nation & World, Page B4**

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